

A Portrait, Fractured in Moments

When I was younger, I thought that life was mostly fair. I've enjoyed chocolate breakfast shakes for as long as I can remember. I have outgoing student loans. I often feel like I am somewhat short on sleep. I wear flip flops all the time. I love listening to the sound of my keys clack as I type. I am worried AI is making everyone stupid. I have applied for at least ten jobs in recent months and will continue applying for more. When I was young, I wanted to be a video game developer, but I gave up on that dream. I have always wanted to be an artist of some kind.

I close my eyes and breath in the cold air as I walk to class, reveling in the sound of my flip-flops flopping against the concrete path. I would like to enjoy the natural peace and serenity of the day, but instead I put on my headphones, using music to drown out the noises of the cars and of the people rushing through their lives. Those sounds aren't serene at all, so I opt for music instead.

I enjoy my classes right now. I finished playing Outer Wilds recently and it made me really emotional. For as long as I can remember, I have had a crippling addiction to lukewarm sweet tea. I sometimes sit in awkward positions. I readjust my glasses constantly when I'm walking around, even when I don't really need to. My favorite band is Pink Floyd, and my favorite album is Wish You Were Here. I'm curious to see how people will react to this piece since it is so very weird. I remember when people around me seemed happy to be alive. I generally prefer cold weather to warm weather. I own three different computers. I worry that I don't drink enough water. I have always been terribly afraid to die, to the point of paranoia.

After a long day of classes and work, I sit down at my desk and release a great sigh. I close my eyes and rest my legs, letting it sink in that I am, in fact, done with my commitments for the day. I lean forward slightly as I peruse my library, deciding what game I'm going to play today. I see a red notification on my taskbar and smile, seeing that one of my

friends wants to play something. With all the work of the day done, I relax and enjoy a nice night of gaming with my friends online. I know that no matter how tired I am by the end of a day, I always have this to look forward to. I'm happy and at peace.

I have always gotten good grades. I enjoy my dad's spaghetti, and my parents laugh at me for it because it's incredibly basic. I don't read as much for pleasure as I would like to, and I hope to remedy that after graduation. I like Doritos and Tostitos. I'm enjoying replaying Terraria. One of my favorite early childhood memories is of fishing with my family, or at least trying to. I am okay at chess, but I have a friend who was the state chess champion multiple times. My Jimmy Johns order is a sandwich with just turkey and cheese on it, then I add four packets of mayonnaise, which is considered by most to be utterly ridiculous.

I'm home for winter break, and I'm alone in my bedroom. I do feel at home in my dorm room, since I've lived in the same dorm for almost four years now, but I've lived in this house with my family for longer, so I feel most at home here. My bed is comfortable and soft, so I lay there with my eyes open, staring up at the ceiling. There was nothing to see up there, but I was thoroughly enjoying the peace and quiet provided by being truly home. It was so quiet. At least, until the dogs decided to start barking.

My favorite video game of all time is Elden Ring. The world feels scarier and generally a bit worse every passing year. I like to think I've at least improved at keeping my room clean during my time at college. 2025 was a fantastic year for video games. I am lucky to have a good number of friends I can rely on in life. I have only been in a single relationship all my life, unfortunately. I enjoy listening to most kinds of music, but I find that I tend to listen to video game soundtracks, prog rock, and metal the most. I remember when it was easier to wake up in the morning.

I lean back in my plastic chair at work. I'm waiting for clients to show up, so I have nothing to do at the moment. I am, quite literally, being paid to do nothing right now. So, while I

wait, I decide to put my headphones on yet again, and I listen to *Wish You Were Here* by Pink Floyd. The album, not the song. The pangs of the guitar, as teardrops falling onto the ground, soothe my soul in a way that nothing else can. The guitar reaches a crescendo, and it sounds like it is screaming in pain, and in sadness. This is something that, more so than natural peace and quiet, grants me true tranquility. I close my eyes and smile as I absorb the synth into my very being.

Until a couple years ago, I didn't wear glasses. The walls of my room back home are nearly covered with posters and vinyl records. I have grown to hate my country. My hair used to be short, but now I keep it long because I think it stands out more and it makes me happy. Whenever I'm home, I try to spend more time with my parents than I used to, in case something happens to them. I am scared to graduate, and I feel like I may have wasted much of my time at college.

I lay in bed reading a book of poetry. The book is *Black Lavender Milk* by Angel Dominguez. This, too, soothes me, yet it also intrigues me. Reading pieces like this, as well as many video games and songs, not only calms me, but it stimulates me. Works of art such as these have both kept me happy and kept me sane over the years. Without art, I fear I would have died long ago. Perhaps not in body, but almost certainly in soul. As long as I have the opportunity to enjoy good art, I feel like I can fight through anything life throws at me.